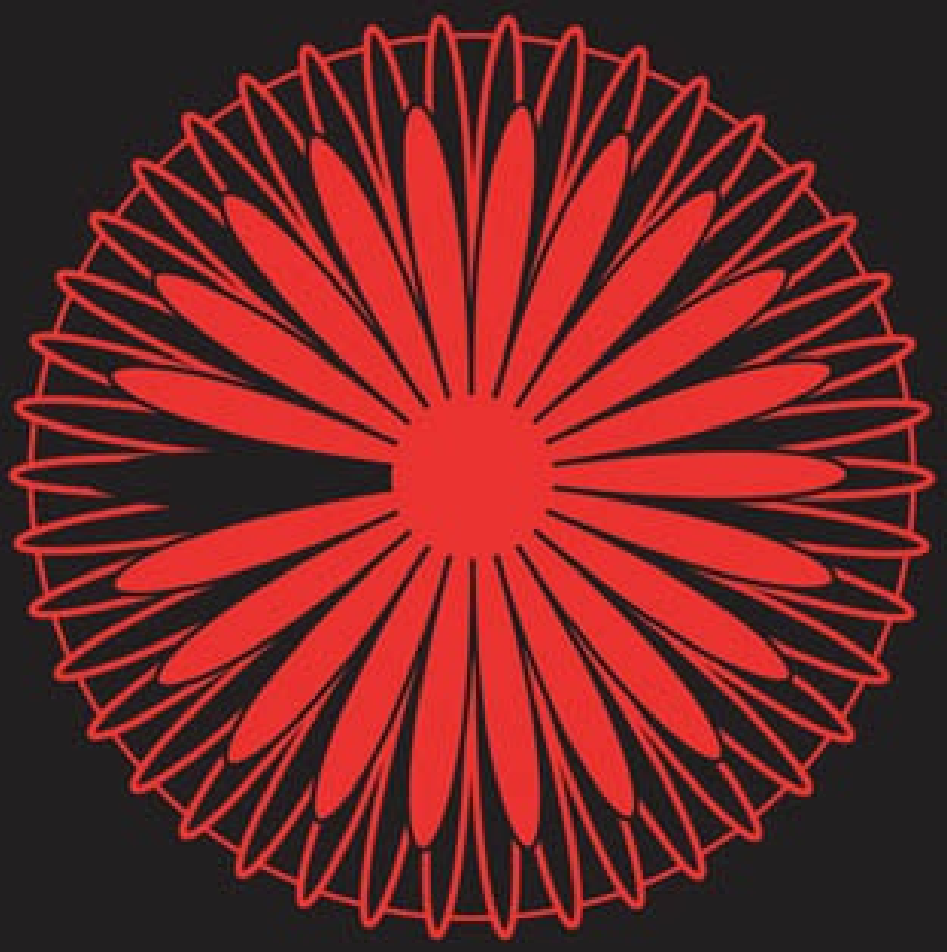
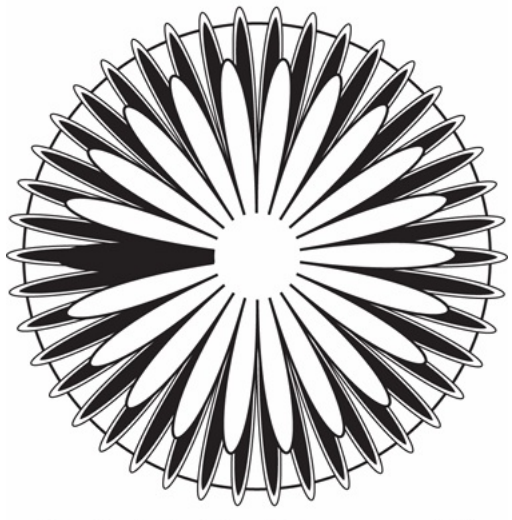


Dashi

M.E.J.Powell

DASHI



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The master walked into town to get a small bag of rice, as much as he could carry all the way back to his mountain retreat. As he passed through the central square he saw young Dashi standing at the gates of the magistrate's mansion waving a red flag.

"What are you doing?" asked the old master.

"O... it's you," Dashi replied, "I am challenging injustice."

"You are baiting a bull. When it comes charging out, do you believe you'll be able to hop on its back?"

Dashi shuffled his feet nervously. "I do not know what will happen to me, but I don't care. I have to stand for my values."

"You do care, you just don't think you do, and that is something different. Besides this isn't standing for your values it is standing for your outrage."

Dashi squinted. "Yes, I am outraged because my values have been challenged. I am flying my flag."

"Exactly, as I said, outrage, not values. And it is outrage the magistrate will feel when you are seen standing out here flouting authority – only the flag that will be flying is your skin!"

"What should I do then?" asked Dashi, "I have to do something."

"Just what I have been saying, know your values. Only then can you know the values of the magistrate."

"I know my values," said Dashi, "Just yesterday they dragged away my brother for poaching deer from the forest! That is what I am protesting."

The master shook his head, but then cocked his ear, "I fear I am not getting through to you." With his staff he swiftly knocked young Dashi's legs out from under him making him fall to the ground with a crash. "How clumsy, here let me help you up," said the master and he offered his hand. Dashi reached up and the master jerked Dashi forward, quickly head butting the young protestor who fell back in a dazed heap. Dashi's face began to turn red with anger.

The sound of hoof falls was now evident, as a troop of cavalry poured into the square and surrounded them, "What's going on here?" asked the head guard. Dashi looked on in horror.

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Dashi gathered sticks of wood. He did so slowly and sombrely. When he had enough, he carried them on his back. And when he'd returned from the forest to the master's home, he placed them into the woodpile, each according to its length, separated each according to its wood, taking a bundle of ten for inside.

Inside the master drank hot water, sitting by the window that looked down the valley to the town below. Dashi came in and sat down. He put his bundle down. The master gave Dashi his cup from which to drink. Dashi sighed, and the master raised his eyebrows and waited.

"Master, I do not love the magistrate."

"Did you expect to?" asked the master.

Dashi said, "Yes. I have been doing as you asked. I try to feel my body, be present, and when the anger comes, see how being angry fills me with a terrible feeling that I carry about. I see it is draining my strength. But I can't seem to let go of it."

The master took the cup back from Dashi, "Ah, did I show you any method for how to let this go?"

Dashi considered this. "No, Master," said Dashi.

"What about the coal in the fire?" said the master.

"Oh, yes, that," said Dashi, "But I want to know what to focus on. What I need to understand."

The master adjusted his robe. He sipped the water. "First of all, there is no secret. What I will tell you, if you dedicated your life to this search, you would find out for yourself." He reached over dumped out the water, and then refilled the cup from the steaming kettle atop the wood stove. "In thirty years or so," he said, "– with help," and passed the very hot cup to Dashi.

"Is that how long it took you?" asked Dashi moving the hot cup from one hand to the other.

"More or less," said the master, "There are other ways that you could learn much faster. I have found my own, and this I will impart."

Dashi bowed. "Thank you master. What is your teaching?"

"If the cup is too hot to hold, put it down."

Dashi nodded and put the cup on the small woodpile by the woodstove and then sat at attention awaiting his master's words of

wisdom. But the master just sat there. 'Ah,' thought Dashi, 'there once was a great master who said – nothing.' He nodded.

"You are nodding. Are you falling asleep?" enquired the master.

Dashi said, "No, master... I understand."

"What do you understand?"

"That it cannot be said in words. Being present. This teaching of yours."

"It isn't mine," shrugged the master.

"No, not yours," said Dashi, "This teaching, the universal teaching of just being."

The master just stared at him, "You are like a kitten tangling yourself up in string. Only *you* manage it without the string."

Dashi slumped in his chair just a tiny bit. "Being present to what is... that's not the teaching?"

The master said, "Everyone knows that. What do you think I've asked you to do? Be in your body. Be present. Don't go off in your thinking so much. But that's only the beginning.

"To see what there is to see, you need be able to experience all the minds freely. If you are not fixated on just one, in your case, thinking mind, then you can easily move amongst them as required."

"How do I move amongst them?" asked Dashi, wondering if that were even the question.

The master said, "Moving is natural. It is not-moving that has been learned. Sticky minds are the difficulty." The master gestured to the cup in the woodpile. "Pick it up."

Dashi took up the hot cup and held it between his burning fingertips. "It's hot," he explained.

"If you grasped the cup and held on with all your might, what would that be like?" asked the master.

"It would be painful," replied Dashi, concerned his master might ask him to do just that.

"Then why do it?" the master asked.

Dashi shook his head, "I wouldn't."

"But you are," insisted the master.

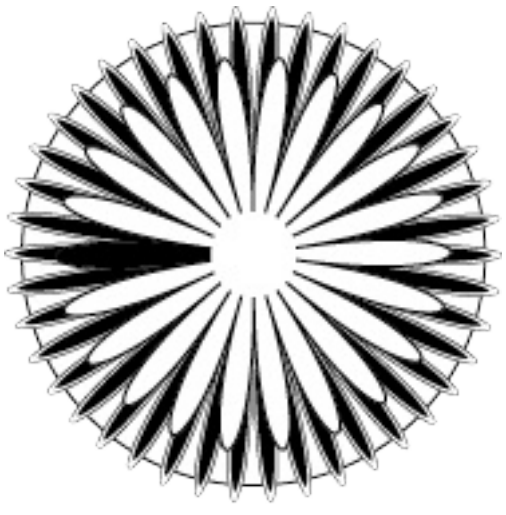
"I'm trying not to," said Dashi shifting the cup back to the other hand for relief.

The master said, "Why listen to me when I tell you to do things that are painful? Don't you have any sense? I will repeat: If the cup is too hot to hold, put it down."

"But you told me to pick it up," said Dashi confused.

The master held up an imaginary bowl in one hand, "You are looking for an answer. If the answer is not in the mind you seek with, you will never find it there. Being stuck in one mind causes unnecessary suffering, like insisting on holding a cup that is too hot to hold." He held up a second imaginary bowl in the other hand, and let the first fall to the floor. "Put that mind down and pick up a different one."

"Ah!" said Dashi, excited, but he misjudged passing the cup back and forth, and it tumbled out of his hands and broke into many many pieces.

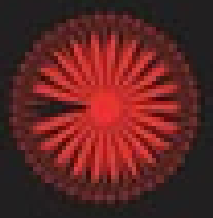


We have not one mind but many.

When a young man asks the master on the mountain for answers – he finds more questions.

Dashi is stuck in thinking mind, worrying himself about an unjust world. But is that what's really behind his thoughts? The master knows the answer.

The question is: can the master teach Dashi how to get himself unstuck? Thus begins the gentle, funny and thought provoking tutelage of the master.



M.F.J. Powell, an expert on being stuck, extends to you a gentle satire on the nature of mind.

After over thirty years of thinking and meditating, looking for the ultimate ideal and finding only an endless chain of one answer transmorphing into another, the idea dawned that the human mind had evolved independent ways of looking at the world to handle different needs. Meaning, there is no ultimate single ideal.

We have not a mind – but minds. A small circle of evolved points of view, neither singular, nor infinite.

The problem now is how to free them all. How to become: unstuck.



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